

WHY IT WORKS

CARL is a structured way to tell the story of an experience: Context (what the situation was), Action (what you did), Result (what happened), Learning (what you took from it). Sequencing a reflection in those four beats makes it far easier for the listener to follow, while you still sound human, responsive and respectful. The influence comes from clarity, not pressure — a point someone can follow reads as clear thinking.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- It is not a script to recite mechanically, and the letters are never meant to be said out loud.
- It is not a way to avoid listening, or to compress someone's emotion into a template.
- It is not a device for forcing the other person into your structure.
- If the structure makes the conversation less humane, it is the wrong tool — slow down and use a simpler move.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: "That was clear, and I know exactly what they took from it."

Principle: People trust a point they can follow. Clear sequencing reads as clear thinking, and its pull comes from clarity and respect rather than pressure.

What you gain

- A clearer path through the point you are making
- Lower cognitive load for the listener
- Better sequencing, so what matters comes first
- A visible learning, so the reflection actually lands
- Credibility that comes from clarity, not pressure
- A shorter, more memorable contribution
- Room for the listener to respond, because the point is finished

Why most people fail at it

- They announce the framework out loud and sound rehearsed.
- They force every sentence into the structure after the listener is already clear.
- They use it when listening or validation should have come first.
- They end on a vague lesson that changes no future behaviour.

CORE FORMULA

Context -> Action -> Result -> Learning -> Context: what the situation was. **Action:** what you did. **Result:** what happened. **Learning:** what you took from it. -> **Worked:** "The launch was slipping. I cut scope to the core feature. We shipped on time. I now agree the must-haves up front." -> **Minimum viable move:** Context: X. Action: Y. Result: Z. Learning: L. -> **Best field rule:** use the structure to organise thought, then speak like a person.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Silently order your point as Context, Action, Result, Learning, then say it in four plain sentences without ever naming the framework.

BEST FOR

- Reflection and debriefs after an event
- Supervision and development conversations

- Interviews and competency-style answers
- Learning stories where the lesson is the whole point
- Making a spoken contribution concise and memorable
- Written updates the reader needs to scan quickly

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. 1 — Decide if CARL fits

Choose the framework only if it serves the moment, and never name it out loud. If emotion is present, or the person just needs a straight answer, use a simpler move instead.

Silent check: Is this a reflection or a request? CARL is for the reflection.

2. 2 — Context — set the scene

One line on the situation, no more. Enough for the listener to picture where you were.

Context: "The launch was slipping by about two weeks."

3. 3 — Action — what you did

State the actual move you made, in plain language. This is the part that shows judgement.

Action: "I cut scope to the one feature customers really needed and re-set the date with the team."

4. 4 — Result — what happened

The consequence of your action, good or mixed. Keep it honest and specific.

Result: "We shipped that core feature on time; the extras followed a month later."

5. 5 — Learning — what changes now

The point of CARL. Name a real learning that is specific enough to change future behaviour — not a vague "I learned a lot."

Learning: "I now agree the must-haves before we start, not halfway through."

6. 6 — Watch and adapt

Notice whether the listener becomes clearer, more engaged or more able to act. If they look confused or resistant, summarise and invite correction rather than pushing the structure harder.

Check: "Does that make sense laid out that way, or have I muddled it?"

FIELD TIP

Scaffolding, not the conversation.

Use CARL to organise your thinking, then take the scaffolding down before you speak. The whole thing turns on a learning specific enough to change what you do next time — that is what separates reflection from a nice-sounding recap.

Situation: "We shipped the core feature on time; what I took from it was to agree the must-haves before we start."

Don't: Don't announce the framework or end on a vague "I learned a lot."

Do: Do keep each step to one plain sentence and make the learning concrete.

PHRASE BANK

Quick framing · One-line openers

- "Quick version: here's what happened, what I did, and what I took from it."
- "Short one — context, action, result, learning."
- "Let me keep this to four beats."
- "Give me thirty seconds and I'll walk it through."
- "Here's the situation, then what I did about it."
- "In brief: the setup, the move, the outcome, the lesson."
- "One example, quickly."

Warm reflection · Sharing a learning story

- "Honestly, here's what I took from it."
- "The thing I learned has stuck with me."
- "It didn't go to plan, and that's the useful part."
- "Looking back, I'd do one thing differently."
- "I'm still glad I tried it, even though it wobbled."

- "What changed for me was small but real."
- "That one taught me more than the wins did."

Meetings and written updates · Work and email

- "Context: where we were. Action: what we changed. Result: what shifted. Learning: what we'll carry forward."
- "Here's the situation, what we did, the outcome, and the takeaway."
- "I'll set the scene, then the decision, then the result."
- "The headline is the result; the rest is background."
- "For the update: what happened, our response, where it landed."
- "Let me label these so you can scan them."
- "The learning we're taking into the next cycle is this."
- "One short paragraph each: context, action, result, learning."

Getting to the point · Cutting to the core

- "The main point is X; the rest is only support."
- "Bottom line first, then the story behind it."
- "Here's what I'd do differently next time."
- "The result was Y, and here's why."
- "I'll give you the lesson, then the evidence for it."
- "Skip to the learning — this is what changes now."
- "One clean next step out of all of this."

When it lands badly · Softening and recovery

- "I made that too structured — let me say it more simply."
- "That may not be the useful frame. Let me back up."
- "I don't want the structure to override the actual issue."
- "What part of that was useful, and what should we drop?"
- "Let me drop the scaffolding and just tell you what happened."
- "I got a bit formulaic there — one plain sentence instead."

Sensitive or high-pressure moments · Check before structuring

- "Before I frame this — is a structured version helpful, or would you rather just talk it through?"
- "I can lay this out clearly, but I want to hear you first."
- "Let me check whether that structure is useful or if we should approach it another way."
- "I'll keep this to one sentence per step, then pause."
- "This one's heavy — tell me if the structure is getting in the way."
- "One line each, and stop me whenever."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Announces the framework and recites every step.
Better: Uses CARL silently to organise a concise answer.
Best: Moves through it so lightly it just sounds like clear thinking.
2. Weak: Ends on a vague lesson that changes nothing.
Better: Names a real, specific learning.
Best: Names the learning and what it changes next time.
3. Weak: Pushes the structure harder when the listener looks lost.
Better: Notices and simplifies.
Best: Drops the frame and checks what the listener actually needs.

DECISION TREE

If The listener needs speed

Use the shortest version — result first, one line each.

"Bottom line: we shipped on time. Quick why, if it's useful."

If The listener needs support

Validate first; delay the framework until the emotion settles.

"That sounds like it was a lot. Want me to lay it out, or just talk it through?"

If The listener needs a story or example

Walk the four beats as a narrative, not as labels.

"Let me tell you how that one actually went."

If The listener needs to act

End with one clean next step.

"So the next step is a scope check at kickoff."

If The listener looks confused

Summarise and invite correction rather than pushing the structure harder.

"Let me boil that down — did I make the point or muddy it?"

SCENARIOS

Work meeting

Make one contribution concise and memorable — four beats, no labels. — "Here's the situation, what we did, where it landed, and what we'll carry forward."

Written update or email

Put each step in a short labelled paragraph so the reader can scan it. — "Context: ... Action: ... Result: ... Learning: ..."

Feedback conversation

Check what kind of feedback is wanted before you structure anything. — "Would it help if I walked through what happened and what I'd change?"

Job interview or competency answer

Answer in four beats, end on the learning, then invite the follow-up. — "The result was we shipped on time; the learning was to agree the must-haves early."

Difficult conversation

One sentence per step, then pause and let them respond. — "Here's what happened. Here's what I did. Here's where it left us."

Debrief after something went wrong

Keep blame out of it and make the learning the point. — "Less about who — more about what we now know for next time."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

Interviewer: "How did you handle the missed deadline?"

You: "I'll use CARL for this. Context: the project was behind. Action: I took action. Result: there was a result. Learning: I learned something."

You: "Context is important, so let me give you a bit more context..."

Why it is weak:

announces the framework out loud

forces empty labels with no real content

keeps adding context after the point is made

sounds rehearsed rather than reflective

With the technique

Interviewer: "How did you handle the missed deadline?"

You: "The launch was slipping about two weeks. I cut scope to the one feature customers really needed and re-set the date with the team."

You: "We shipped that core feature on time, and the extras followed a month later."

You: "What I took from it was to agree the must-haves before we start, not halfway through."

Interviewer: "What would you have done differently?"

You: "Flagged the slip a week earlier. That's the bit I've changed since."

Why this works:

moves through context, action, result and learning without naming them

keeps each step to one plain sentence
ends on a specific learning that changes future behaviour
adapts to the follow-up instead of defending the structure
Same four beats, never announced. The listener feels clarity, not choreography.

COMMON MISTAKES

Announcing the framework

Sounds like: "I'm going to use CARL here..."

Better: Just tell the story in four plain beats.

Over-structuring — making CARL matter more than the person or the point

Sounds like: Forcing every sentence into Context / Action / Result / Learning.

Better: Let the point lead; use the structure only to organise it.

Over-explaining after the point has landed

Sounds like: Adding more context once the structure has done its job.

Better: Stop once it is clear and give them room to respond.

Structuring when emotion is present

Sounds like: "Let me lay this out..." while they're still upset.

Better: Validate first, then structure the information.

A vague learning

Sounds like: "So yeah, I learned a lot from it."

Better: "I now agree the must-haves before we start."

Not checking it landed

Sounds like: Moving on without seeing if they followed.

Better: "Does that make sense laid out that way?"

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- The listener becomes clearer.
- They ask a more specific question.
- They summarise your point back accurately.
- They can choose a next step.
- They stay with the sequence rather than tuning out.
- The learning lands and they build on it.

Signs to adjust

- They look confused or go quiet — simplify or slow down.
- They challenge the framing — check what they actually need.
- They need the human context before the structure — give that first.
- It starts to sound defensive or self-protective — drop the frame.
- It sounds performative, salesy or like a lecture — stop.
- Emotion rises — validate before you structure.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- You need a direct recommendation, not a reflection
- Reflection would sound self-protective or like an excuse
- Emotion is high and listening or validation should come first
- There is shame, grief, anger or a real power imbalance
- The decision is high-stakes and needs a straight answer
- Physical safety or an emergency takes priority

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: I made that too structured — let me say it more simply.

- "I made that too structured — let me say it more simply."
- "That may not be the useful frame. Let me back up."
- "I don't want the structure to override the actual issue."
- "What part of that was useful, and what should we drop?"
- "Let me drop the labels and just tell you what happened."
- "I got a bit formulaic there — here's the plain version."
- "Forget the framework for a second: the real point is this."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Clarity chain

CARL -> Summary check

- "...and the learning was to agree scope up front."
- "Does that match what you were expecting to hear?"

Action chain

CARL -> Clean request

- "...so the fix is a scope check at kickoff."
- "Could you add that to next week's agenda?"

Autonomy chain

CARL -> Autonomy release

- "That's what I'd take from it."
- "But it's your call how you'd handle it."

Emotion-first chain

Validate the concern -> CARL

- "That deadline sounded genuinely stressful."
- "Here's what happened and what I'd change..."

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC047 — STAR

STAR (Situation, Task, Action, Result) is the interview cousin — reach for it when the emphasis is on what you did and delivered. Use CARL when the point of the story is the learning, not just the result.

TC050 — What? So what? Now what?

What? So what? Now what? is a lighter three-beat reflection. Use it for a quick debrief; use CARL when you also need the concrete action and result in between.

TC042 — PREP

PREP (Point, Reason, Example, Point) leads with the conclusion to persuade. Use CARL when you are reflecting on an experience rather than arguing a position.

TC040 — Meaning reflection

Meaning reflection mirrors the meaning behind what someone else said. Use CARL to structure your own account; use Meaning reflection when the move is to reflect their point back.

TC048 — SCQA

SCQA (Situation, Complication, Question, Answer) frames a problem for the reader. Use CARL when you are narrating what happened and what you learned, not setting up a question.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Write it out

Take a real experience and write a 60-second response using Context -> Action -> Result -> Learning.

Day 2 — Cut it down

Cut yesterday's response by a third — down to about 30 seconds — without losing the core point.

Day 3 — Sharpen the learning

Rewrite the Learning line so it names something specific that would change what you do next time; delete any "I learned a

lot."

Day 4 — Two voices

Say it aloud twice — once as a visible structure with labels, once as plain speech. Notice how much better the plain version lands.

Day 5 — Serve the listener

For your response, ask: would this help the other person understand, decide or act? Trim anything that only makes you sound polished.

Day 6 — Practise a recovery

Rehearse one recovery line so you can drop the scaffolding smoothly if it lands badly — e.g. "I made that too structured; let me say it more simply."

Day 7 — Use it live

In one real conversation, use CARL silently — four plain sentences, never named — and watch whether the listener becomes clearer.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use CARL to serve the listener, not to sound polished?
- Was the core point clear?
- Did I keep it concise?
- Was the learning specific enough to change next time?
- Did I adapt when the listener needed something else?
- Did I preserve the other person's autonomy and dignity?